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Industry Connect

Hugo Barra talks about India strategy and more

Chinese manufacturer Xiaomi has caused quite a stir in the market, but consumers are getting frustrated by the day, with every sale lasting for a matter of seconds. While that is the main question on everybody's mind, some have also asked about other things. We put those questions directly to the company, in a conversation with Xiaomi Vice President of international affairs, Hugo Barra. He talked about frustrated customers, Flipkart, the Mi4 and Xiaomi's plans for India.

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Q At the launch you said that Xiaomi will partner with other e-commerce firms in India. Are you open to those who approach you?

Hugo: We said we were open to other partnerships, but we have no near term plans of working with other partners. We're very close with Flipkart and the partnership is working well. We are always open to companies that approach us with good ideas. We love hearing talking about interesting ways to do things. But we're a very, very focused company.

Q Xiaomi's strategy revolves a lot around building a community and ecosystem of its own. What are you doing in India and what kinds of response are you getting?

Hugo: There's a lot of things that we're doing. We have our social media communities, which are growing. We just crossed 30,000 followers on Facebook today. We also have the MiUI community, which is becoming stronger. These are Android MiUI fans, who have followed us for a long time and who want to try out the UI even before they hold a Mi device in their hand. In general we are very very happy with the fact that the Android community is embracing us. I had a get together with users in Bangalore on Sunday, where I just randomly posted "hey guys, why don't we get together for a few drinks..." and close to 50 people showed up with notice of a few hours. These were Android fans, MiUI fans, who were really curious to play with our devices and we spent a few hours just talking.



Hugo Barra
Vice President, International Affairs, Xiaomi

Indian users are very curious, receptive and demanding. I was always very excited about the idea of coming here, but I have been pleasantly surprised with how this community is embracing us.

Q So could you tell us when the Redmi 1S and Note will be launched in India?

Hugo: We're also finalising that. It will be in the next few weeks, but we haven't finalised a date yet. But Redmi 1S will be first.

Q Your numbers so far have been relatively low. Why is Xiaomi not increasing the number of units that it puts up on sale?

Hugo: We are. Steadily so. Our numbers for next week will be a little bit higher as well. We are coming in slowly. We had our manufacturing schedule set for months and I have to say that we had underestimated the demand here.

Q We have received some reports of issues, including the review unit that was sent to us. How do you plan to tackle these?

Hugo: If someone has any kind of issue with their device and we can not address their problem over the phone, they can immediately get a replacement. Even if they think there's an issue, software problem or the phone is not working the way it should, they can call our customer support. If we determine that it is a hardware or software fault, then we'll immediately replace the unit.

Q If you have to fix an unit, will that be sent to China to fix?

Hugo: Everything is fixed in India. We're working really hard to make sure that service centres have parts in stock and if the device can not be repaired in the service centre then it will immediately be swapped.

Q Are you planning to compete with the market leaders? Is there anyone you think as your main competitors?

Hugo: Uhh, don't really think about the world that way. We're always thinking about building the best devices and not thinking about which competitors to go after. We're an engineering company.

Q What kind of a timeline can we expect for the Mi4 launch?

Hugo: It'll be towards the end of the year, around December.

You can read the rest of the interview online at <http://digit.in/hugobarrainterview>